

SWIPE →

— START HERE: THE WHOLE MAP

One question, *four hundred years.*

"Can this person earn their keep?" The question that sorted people then still sorts them at work now.

Three threads, one story.

The history. My research report, *On the Bus or Off the Bus*, traces how institutions learned to measure, label, and sort people.

The vocabulary. Names for the tactics that history left behind, and the ways they show up at work.

My story. Youngest of nine, the family scapegoat, diagnosed with autism, and still employed where I learned all of this.

A few rungs on a long ladder

1835	Quetelet describes the “average man,” and the middle becomes the measure.
1883	Galton coins the word “eugenics.”
1905	Binet builds an intelligence scale to find children who need help. Others turn it into a gate.
1927	In *Buck v. Bell*, the U.S. Supreme Court upholds forced sterilization.
1990	The Americans with Disabilities Act becomes law.



The tactics didn't retire.

They got job titles.

SAME MOVES, SMALLER STAKES

Not the same harm. The same playbook.

THEN		AT WORK NOW
A case file written about you	→	A performance file you never see
A test score cutoff	→	A metric threshold
A label that ends the conversation	→	“Attitude problem.” “Not a culture fit.”
Decisions made about you, without you	→	The meeting about you that you're not in
Disbelieved before you speak	→	Credibility laundering

44%

was the pooled rate of victimization among people with autism, across 34 studies.

People the system once sorted out are still the easiest to target, and the least believed when they say so.

Source: Trundle et al. (2023), *Trauma, Violence, & Abuse*. Rates varied a lot between studies.

People spoke back, and it worked.

In 1993, Jim Sinclair gave a talk called “Don't Mourn for Us.” In 2012, Damian Milton named the **double empathy problem**: a misunderstanding between two kinds of minds runs both ways.

Every gain started with someone finding the words.

Each week goes one layer deeper

1. Metrics as bullying: when the number becomes the boss.
2. Masking, and why people who mask well get missed.
3. The credibility gap: why sorted people are easier to target.
4. Accommodations on paper versus in practice.
5. The double empathy problem at work.
6. Plus a “history echo” each week from the timeline.



READ THE WHOLE MAP

The history, the vocabulary, and my story

Long-form on Substack, with every source listed.

Link in bio. Save this as your map for the series, and follow along.